here they call a ranch, but it sure looks like goat country to me. Where would you ride a horse?

After seven miles of twists and turns, the road straightened out briefly and we were surrounded by a stand of oak trees; then we turned off the road, went through a gate, and started down another narrow road.

Pretty soon, we were passing through another lovely grove of trees and suddenly we emerged on a huge green meadow with rugged hills stretching far beyond it. Across the meadow I saw a tiny house.

I took one look at the view and was ready to buy, even before we reached the house, but Bill kept saying, “Shut up. If you’re gonna buy it, don’t tell the owner you like it.”

The owner was a cattleman named Ray Cornelius. He put us on horses and we took a ride over the place. Well, after that, I was really sold.

The previous Christmas Eve, Ray and his wife had lost their daughter (who by coincidence had been a classmate of Patti’s) in an automobile accident; until then, they’d kept the ranch mostly for her to ride on. Now they no longer wanted it, but they were hesitant to sell the ranch because, they told us, they were afraid it would be taken over by someone who wouldn’t love it as much or have as much feeling for it as they did.

Nancy and I said we’d bestow all the love in the world on the ranch, and pretty soon, we sold our land near San Diego and with that money bought Tip Top Ranch.

The ranch, which covered 688 acres, was named Tip Top after a mountain peak that marked a dividing point for rainfall in the Santa Ynez range: Rain that fell on one side flowed toward the Pacific Ocean, rain that fell on the other side drained into the Santa Ynez Valley and then found its way to the ocean.

Nancy and I chose another name, Rancho del Cielo, “Ranch in the Sky,” for that’s what it was.